CUISINE

Odisha has one of the great heritage cuisines of India, characterised by complex flavours and deft use of seasonal and locally available produce and ingredients. The temple food of Odisha is the stuff of legend, especially the Mahaprasad of the Jagannath Temple in Puri which is made in earthen pots.

THESE ARE SOME OF ODISHA'S MOST ICONIC DISHES

DALMA

This is essentially dal (lentil) cooked with an assortment of vegetables and spices. Apart from being a part of the main course, people relish the dish in a variety of combinations like Dalma with Pitha (local pancake), Dalma with Vada (fried lentil cake), etc. The high protein and healthy dish is the most essential component of any Odia meal. Habisa Dalma is a variant that is made during the holy month of Kartika.

PAKHALA

Pakhala is a great way to reuse leftover rice and is an extremely nutritious preparation. Essentially rice that has been fermented overnight with water, pakhala is served with fried fish or a selection of dry vegetables such as potato and brinjal and an array of condiments which some consider to be the highlight of the meal. Primarily consumed in the summer months for its cooling, replenishing properties, pakhala is favoured by farmers who toil long hours in the fields. Every year on March 20, the Odias celebrate Pakhala Dibas and ensure that this iconic dish remains as popular as ever.

MACHA BESARA

There is always fish on the table in an Odia home. Macha besara is a traditional fish curry from Odisha and features rohu fish cooked in mustard sauce with dry mango slices added for a tangy twist. When paired with hot rice, this is a filling and healthy meal that's simple to prepare but packed with flavour, like most Odia dishes.

CHHENA PODA

Legend has it that Odisha's most famous dessert came about as a result of a baker's happy accident: he or she added sugar to some leftover cottage cheese and baked it in a still-warm oven overnight. Cottage cheese and sugar are combined to make the traditional Odia sweet of chhena poda. The dish is baked in an earthen oven lined with sal leaves, which imparts a delicious smoky flavour to it.

RASAGOLA

Rasagola, also known as kheer mohana in Odisha, is a dish traditionally used as bhog in Puri's Jagannath Temple to appease the goddess Lakshmi. This well-liked dessert is based on curdled milk, which is then drained of its whey before being kneaded into round balls and cooked in sugar syrup to make them fluffy, light, and juicy. In 2019, the Odisha Rasagola received the prestigious GI tag.